

Initial Placement for Fruchterman–Reingold Force Model with Coordinate Newton Direction

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Abstract

The Fruchterman–Reingold (FR) force model is widely used in force-directed graph drawing, and multilevel approaches such as `sfdp` in Graphviz scale these methods effectively. A crucial step in multilevel schemes is refinement, which improves the graph layout typically performed with the FR algorithm. For this refinement, optimization-based methods, such as L-BFGS, often yield better layouts by exploiting past gradient information. However, they suffer from high per-iteration costs for large graphs and difficulty in handling highly twisted graphs.

In this research, we propose a new initial placement based on the stochastic coordinate descent to accelerate the optimization process. We first reformulate the problem as a discrete optimization problem using a hexagonal lattice and then iteratively update a randomly selected vertex along the coordinate Newton direction with low per-iteration costs.

We demonstrate the effectiveness of our method through numerical experiments, showing that our initial placement leads to faster convergence and higher-quality layouts compared to naive optimization approaches. We also discuss how the coordinate Newton direction can be applied to other graph-related problems from an optimization perspective.

1 Introduction

Graph drawing is a fundamental task in information visualization, and force-directed methods are among the most widely used approaches. In these methods, vertices are treated as particles subject to forces, and the resulting equilibrium layouts are regarded as desirable visualizations. Among established force models [9, 22], the Fruchterman–Reingold (FR) force model [11] is particularly prominent for its intuitive formulation, flexibility, and simplicity. It is implemented in libraries such as NetworkX [16], Graphviz [10], and igraph [7].

Obtaining the equilibrium layout of the force models has been a subject of extensive research. The FR algorithm [11] is an original iterative method that simulates the forces to find an equilibrium, but it struggles with its scalability. Its convergence becomes prohibitively slow on large graphs, prompting the development of multilevel coarsen-refine schemes such as the Scalable Force-Directed Placement (`sfdp`) method in Graphviz [10, 21]. While these frameworks extend the applicability, their refinement stage still relies heavily on the FR algorithm, leaving room for improvement.

The critical issue in the refinement step is that the twist slows down the force simulation. The term twist refers to unnecessary folded and tangled structures in the visualized graph [6, 31]. The results in Fig. 1 highlight these twist issues. Even if a graph has a

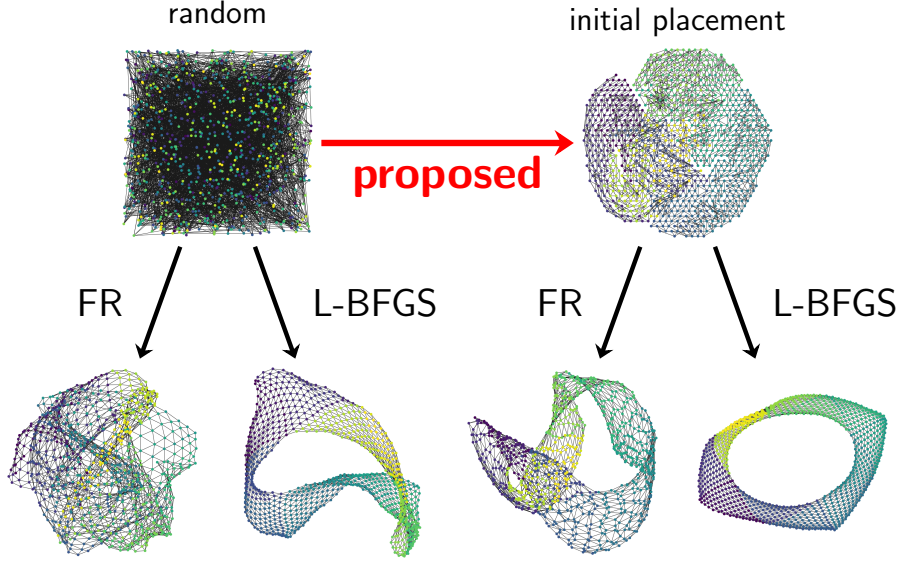


Figure 1: Comparison of the algorithms for the jagmesh1.

simple structure, twists often occur, which cancel out the forces and lead to stagnation and suboptimal visualization outcomes.

To address the twist problem and obtain better equilibrium layouts, we utilize continuous optimization techniques. The L-BFGS algorithm [24] is a general purpose optimization algorithm and more practical approach [20], achieving better results for several force models including the FR force model and the Kamada–Kawai (KK) model [22]. While L-BFGS algorithm can partially address the twist problem, it can require many iterations with high per-iteration cost. It may fail to achieve optimal visualization within a limited number of iterations as shown in Fig. 1. A Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD)-based method, which updates the positions of two vertices at a time based on a single edge, has recently been proposed for the KK layout. [22, 35]. While it is highly regarded, applying it to the force model in the FR algorithm is challenging due to its relatively complex structure. Refer to Sec. 6 for more details.

Pre-processing to find a better initial placement is another optimization-based approach to solve the twist problem. A pre-processing step with Simulated Annealing (SA) is known to be effective since SA, the optimization method, can avoid getting stuck in local optima and leads to a better visualization combined with the FR algorithm [14]. Still, as discussed in Sec. 3.3, this work focuses only on unweighted, simple-structured, and small-scale graphs.

In this paper, we propose a new initial placement for the force model in the FR algorithm. We provide an initial placement with fewer twists than random placement within a short time, accelerating the subsequent optimization process. We can use both FR and L-BFGS algorithms to obtain the final placement. This work extends the applicability of the initial placement idea to larger-scale, weighted, and complicated structured graphs. To achieve this, we optimize the position of vertices one by one with the coordinate Newton direction, leveraging the inherent structure and the sparsity of graphs. We also demonstrate its effectiveness through various experiments.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows.

- In Sec. 2, we provide the technical definitions of the FR force model.
- In Sec. 3, we review some related work.

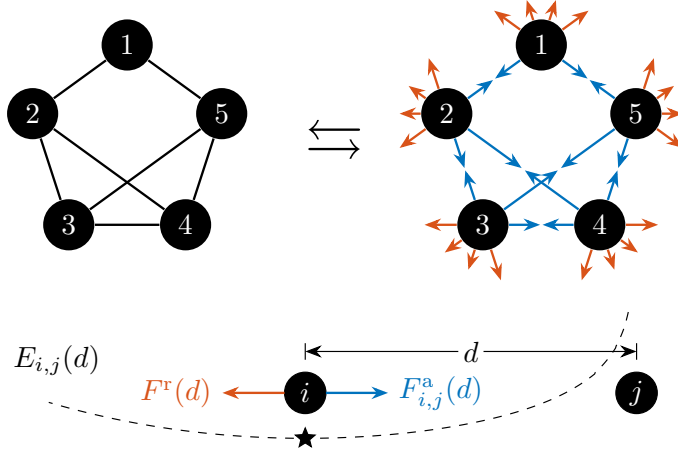


Figure 2: In the model, forces act on every pair of vertices. Forces $F_{i,j}^a(d)$ and $F^r(d)$ work between vertices i and j . The equilibrium of them is achieved at $d = k / \sqrt[3]{a_{i,j}}$, which equals k when $a_{i,j} = 1$.

- In Sec. 4, we present our initial placement algorithm.
- In Sec. 5, we report experimental comparisons.
- In Sec. 6, we discuss our approach and its potential applications.
- In Sec. 7, we conclude the paper and discuss future work.

2 Preliminaries

Fruchterman and Reingold [11] proposed the FR algorithm with its force model for graph drawing based on the physical analogy of the system of particles. **Note that we distinguish between the FR algorithm and the FR model. The former is an iterative method that simulates the forces, while the latter is a mathematical formulation of the forces.** Through the simulation of these forces, the FR algorithm seeks equilibrium positions. In contrast to this ordinary approach, energy-based methods seek equilibrium. A local minimum of the energy function Φ yields an equilibrium position since $\nabla\Phi(X)$ corresponds to the forces. In this sense, the force-based and energy-based perspectives are equivalent as both capture equilibrium, illustrated in Fig. 2.

Let us formally define the optimization problem for obtaining the equilibrium layout. Let $G = (V, E)$ be an undirected graph with vertex set $V = \{1, \dots, n\}$ and edge set E . Each edge $\{i, j\} \in E$ has positive weight $a_{i,j} = a_{j,i} \in \mathbb{R}$. For convenience, we set $a_{i,j} = 0$ for $\{i, j\} \notin E$. The force model in the FR algorithm assumes forces between vertices. For vertices i and j with distance $d > 0$, an attractive force $F_{i,j}^a(d)$ and a repulsive force $F^r(d)$ are defined as

$$F_{i,j}^a(d) := \frac{a_{i,j}d^2}{k}, \quad F^r(d) := -\frac{k^2}{d},$$

where $k > 0$ is a constant parameter, often set to $1/\sqrt{n}$ [11]. The scalar potentials of these forces [20] are given by

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_{i,j}^a(d) &:= \int_0^d F_{i,j}^a(r) dr = \frac{a_{i,j}d^3}{3k}, & \Phi^r(d) &:= \int_1^d F^r(r) dr = -k^2 \log d, \\ \Phi_{i,j}(d) &:= \Phi_{i,j}^a(d) + \Phi^r(d). \end{aligned}$$

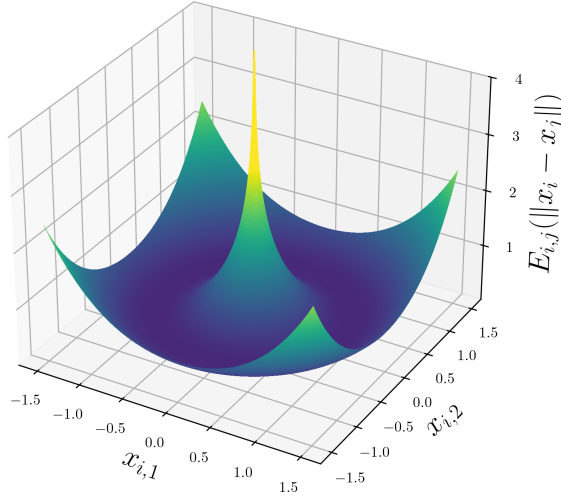


Figure 3: The energy function $\Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|)$ for $x_i = (x_{i,1}, x_{i,2})$, $x_j = (0, 0)$, $a_{i,j} = 1$, and $k = 1$.

For simplicity, we define $\Phi_{i,j}(0) = \infty$.¹ Let $\|\cdot\|$ denote the Euclidean norm in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Then, the problem is to minimize the energy with $X := (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi(X) := \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|). \quad (1)$$

Note that the summation is taken over ordered pairs (i, j) . For undirected graphs, this includes both (i, j) and (j, i) and therefore only scales the objective value by a constant factor. We keep this form since it extends naturally to directed or asymmetric weights.

While the energy function $\Phi_{i,j}(d)$ is convex and minimized when $d = k/\sqrt[3]{a_{i,j}}$ for a positive $a_{i,j}$, a function $x_i \mapsto \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|)$ is non-convex for a fixed x_j . Additionally, $\Phi_{i,j}$ is not Lipschitz continuous near $d = 0$, as illustrated in Fig. 3. These properties highlight the difficulty of the optimization problem.

3 Related Work

We next summarize the existing literature relevant to our work.

3.1 Optimization Approach

Optimization-based methods for graph drawing have been actively investigated. Representative approaches include GPU acceleration [13], machine learning techniques [29], and multi-objective formulations [1]. Among optimization-based approaches, our attention is on the underlying optimization algorithms itself. In this section, we review the L-BFGS algorithm.

The L-BFGS algorithm, a renowned and widely used optimization method, consistently outperforms the original FR algorithm in speed and layout quality [20]. It uses the function value and the gradient to find the local optima. We define the sum of terms associated

¹We can also use $-k^2 \log(d + \epsilon^r)$ for $\Phi^r(d)$ to prevent divergence, where ϵ^r is constant.

with the vertex x_i as Φ_i , which is explicitly given by

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|) + \Phi_{j,i}(\|x_j - x_i\|) \right).$$

The i -th column of the gradient $\nabla \Phi(X) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ is

$$\begin{aligned} (\nabla \Phi(X))_i &:= \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) = \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{(a_{i,j} + a_{j,i})\|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{2k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j) \\ &= 2 \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j}\|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j). \end{aligned}$$

The graph layout can be obtained as the result of optimization using the L-BFGS solver with the gradient described above. A common choice for the initial solution is a random placement of nodes within the bounding box $\{(x_i^{(1)}, x_i^{(2)}) \mid 0 \leq x_i^{(1)} \leq 1, 0 \leq x_i^{(2)} \leq 1\}$ [32]. However, when the input is highly twisted or otherwise ill-conditioned, L-BFGS can suffer from large per-iteration costs: each iteration operates on the full set of coordinates, which limits its ability to untangle local geometric defects.

todo. describe here.

3.2 Multilevel Approach

Multilevel approaches such as `sfdp` [21] in Graphviz are important prior work for obtaining the equilibrium layout of the force model, i.e., solving the problem (1). These methods use hierarchical coarsening and refinement to achieve efficient layout computation for large graphs.

Our work is complementary to such multilevel methods. Optimization techniques such as L-BFGS can be directly applied to the refinement stages within multilevel pipelines. Since the approaches proposed in this study can be incorporated into multilevel frameworks with appropriate modifications, our primary objective is to quantify and enhance the refinement procedure itself. Therefore, we deliberately exclude coarsening and other approximation steps from the present analysis. For further details on multilevel approaches, the reader is referred to [2, 17, 33].

3.3 Initial Placement Approach

A preprocessing step with Simulated Annealing (SA) is known to be effective [14] since SA can avoid getting stuck in local optima and leads to better visualization, combined with the FR algorithm. Let

$$Q^{\text{circle}} := \{(\cos(2\pi i/n), \sin(2\pi i/n)) \mid 1 \leq i \leq n\}$$

be the points on a unit circle in $\mathbb{R}^2$. For an unweighted graph G , let E_2 be a set of vertex pairs with a shortest path distance equal to 2. Let $\angle(a, b)$ denote the angle between the lines from the origin to the points a and b , measured in the interval $(-\pi, \pi]$. This study [14] defines the problem for the preprocessing of graph drawing as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} &\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} && \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E \cup E_2} |\angle(x_i, x_j)|, \\ &\text{subject to} && x_i \in Q^{\text{circle}} \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\ &&& x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n. \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

The problem (2) is a discrete optimization problem where the placement is limited to Q^{circle} and uses angles, not the function Φ in the problem (1). This study obtains a faster and better visualization by setting the result of Simulated Annealing (SA) for the problem (2) as an initial placement for the FR algorithm.

Still, the following limitations remain:

- The target graphs are restricted to unweighted ones.
- The layout is confined to a simple circle, which could be ineffective for complex structured graphs.
- The neighborhood in the SA is the random swapping of two vertices, making the optimization process inefficient for large-scale graphs.
- $|E_2|$ could be $\Theta(|V|^2)$, unable to leverage the sparsity of graphs if it exists.

We address these limitations, and our study is an extension of this work.

4 Proposed Algorithm

With the prior studies in Sec. 3.1, this section proposes Algorithm 1, a new initial placement algorithm for the problem (1). The algorithm solves a discrete optimization problem with stochastic coordinate descent to find an initial placement with fewer twists. This algorithm leverages the properties of the objective function to determine the initial layout quickly. By combining it with optimization methods like the L-BFGS algorithm, it enhances the overall convergence speed of graph drawing through optimization.

4.1 Newton Direction and Coordinate Newton Direction

Consider a strictly convex function $g: \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ at x_0 . The Newton direction $d = -\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1} \nabla g(x_0)$ is an optimal direction for the second order approximation of g :

$$g(x_0) + \nabla g(x_0)^\top (x - x_0) + \frac{1}{2} (x - x_0)^\top \nabla^2 g(x_0) (x - x_0).$$

$x = x_0 + d$ is the minimizer of this approximation. Note that the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 g(x_0)$ is positive definite since g is strictly convex. Although the Newton direction is essential in various iterative methods, it requires the computation of the inverse Hessian $\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$, posing a high computational cost for large-scale problems.

Still, we can leverage the concept of the Newton direction in a different manner, the coordinate Newton direction. Instead of computing the inverse Hessian $\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1}$ in the entire variable space $\mathbb{R}^n$, we restrict the variable x to its coordinate block x_i with fewer dimensions, and compute $\nabla^2 g_i(x_i)^{-1} \nabla g_i(x_i)$ where g_i is a restricted function of g to x_i . Since the coordinate Newton direction computation is much cheaper than that of the Newton direction, we can repeat this procedure many times. In general, this idea is known as stochastic coordinate descent [34] or Randomized Subspace Newton [15] in a broader context.

In particular, this coordinate Newton direction has an apparent natural affinity to the problem (1). We can compute the coordinate Newton direction by taking the position x_i of the vertex i as the coordinate block. Although directly applying this idea to the problem (1) is challenging, as we will discuss in Sec. 6, we leverage this coordinate Newton direction to propose our algorithm.

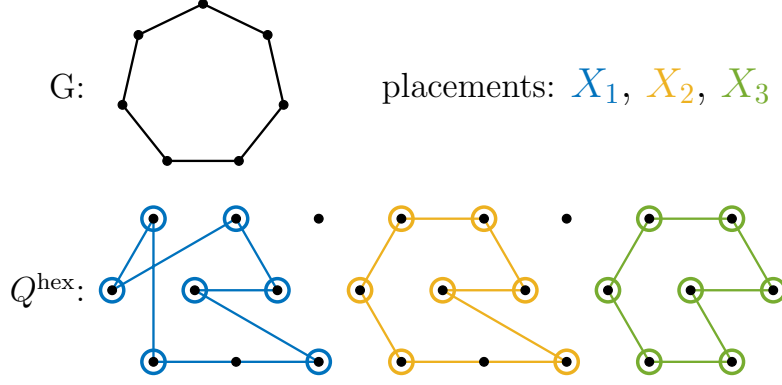


Figure 4: Concept of Q . The assignment from V to a discrete point placement Q , especially a hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} . Apparently, among the three placements, the right one is the best placement for the problem (3).

181 4.2 Discrete Optimization Problem for Initial Placement

182 Even at the expense of accuracy, obtaining an approximate solution quickly is crucial for
 183 the initial placement. To obtain it, we simplify the problem (1) into a more manageable
 184 and well-behaved discrete optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned}
 & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi^a(X) := \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}, \\
 & \text{subject to} \quad x_i \in Q^{\text{hex}} \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\
 & \quad \quad \quad x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n,
 \end{aligned} \tag{3}$$

185 where

$$Q^{\text{hex}} := \left\{ \left(q + \frac{1}{2}r, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}r \right) \mid q \in \mathbb{Z}, r \in \mathbb{Z} \right\}. \tag{4}$$

186 First, the problem (1) is equivalent to the following:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|.$$

187 This formulation separates the $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ terms from $\Phi_{i,j}^a$ and the $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ terms from Φ^r .

188 Here, following previous research mentioned in Sec. 3.3, we fix the possible positions x_i
 189 of each vertex i to a discrete set of points Q , where $|Q| \geq |V|$. It means that we consider
 190 the following:

$$\begin{aligned}
 & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|, \\
 & \text{subject to} \quad x_i \in Q \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\
 & \quad \quad \quad x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n.
 \end{aligned}$$

191 The goal is to simplify the objective function and choose Q appropriately to derive a
 192 well-simplified problem.

Due to the sparsity of many practical graphs, $|E| \ll |V|^2$ holds. To leverage this sparsity for simplification, we want to drop the second term that arises from the repulsive energy Φ^r :

$$-\sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|.$$

We impose a condition on Q such that $\|q_i - q_j\| \geq \epsilon$ for all $q_i, q_j \in Q$ with $q_i \neq q_j$. In this case, the term above is negligible. Since $\Phi^r(d) = -k^2 \log d$ is a convex function such that it decreases monotonically concerning d , for sufficiently large d , the value of $-k^2 \log d$ does not vary excessively. For too small d , we can prevent the divergence of the energy function by setting ϵ . Thus, under this condition, we drop the second term and derive the problem as:

$$\begin{aligned} & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} && \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}, \\ & \text{subject to} && x_i \in Q \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\ & && x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n. \end{aligned}$$

This means that we skip to consider the $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ pairs (all pairs of $\{i, j\}$ with $1 \leq i < j \leq n$) by fixing the possible point placement in advance, reducing the computational complexity to $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ and thus offering significant speedup. See Fig. 4 for a visual explanation.

We can consider various placements for the Q , including Q^{circle} [14]. In this study, we adopt a hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} [23, 27] defined by Eq. (4) (see Fig. 4). When minimizing the objective function that arises from the attractive energy Φ^a , it is advantageous for the points to cluster as closely as possible. In this context, the hexagonal lattice is known for its densest packing structure in space with the least distance ϵ between points [5] and offers computational simplicity. Thus, Q^{hex} is a suitable choice, and we have derived the problem (3).

4.3 Newton Direction for Discrete Optimization

Next, we solve the discrete optimization problem (3). Although this problem is challenging to solve just using simple methods, the coordinate Newton direction of a randomly selected vertex i provides significant insights as mentioned in Sec. 4.1. Therefore, we can offer a high-quality solution to the problem. Let the restricted objective function $\Phi_i^a(x_i)$ be

$$\Phi_i^a(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}.$$

Its gradient and Hessian matrix are

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} (x_i - x_j), \\ \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j}}{k \|x_i - x_j\|} (x_i - x_j)(x_i - x_j)^\top. \end{aligned}$$

This means Φ_i^a is strictly convex, assuring the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)$ is positive definite. This is a large difference from the functions $\Phi(X)$ in the problem (1) and $\Phi^a(X)$ in the problem (3), which are non-convex.

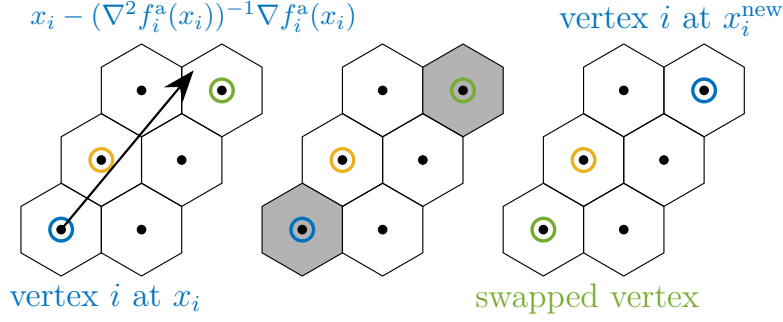


Figure 5: One iteration of the proposed algorithm. Step 1. Compute the coordinate Newton direction (blue). Step 2. Decide x_i^{new} by rounding the direction and adding a random vector. Step 3. Move the vertex and swap the vertices if necessary (swap blue and green vertices).

221 The ordinary updated rule with the coordinate Newton direction is

$$x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i).$$

222 x_i^{new} may not be in the hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} in the problem (3). Thus, we project this
 223 x_i^{new} onto the nearest point in Q^{hex} . We also empirically found that adding a random
 224 noise vector to the Newton direction is effective for the optimization process, a strategy
 225 similar to the SA in Sec. 3.3. This randomness can help to escape from local minima
 226 and to explore the solution space more effectively. In conclusion, the updated rule for the
 227 vertex i is

$$x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{round}(x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i) + t \cdot r),$$

228 where $\text{round}(\hat{x})$ denotes the operation assigning $\hat{x}$ to the nearest point in the hexagonal
 229 lattice Q^{hex} , r is a random vector with a unit norm, and the parameter t is gradually
 230 decreased as the iterations proceed and is designed to converge to zero eventually.

231 If there is a vertex j such that $x_j = x_i^{\text{new}}$, we swap the positions x_i and x_j to satisfy
 232 the condition $x_i \neq x_j$. Otherwise, we just update x_i to x_i^{new} . Refer to Fig. 5 for a visual
 233 explanation. Repeating this procedure yields an approximate solution to the problem (3).

234 4.4 Optimal Scaling

235 The obtained solution could be too small or too large since we did not care about the scale
 236 ϵ . Thus, as the final step, we rescale the placement to improve it.

237 Let us formulate the optimization problem for the scaling factor $s > 0$. For an initial
 238 placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$, we scale it as $x_i \leftarrow s x_i$ for all i . The problem of minimizing
 239 $\Phi(X)$ through scaling is equivalent to minimizing $\phi(s)$ defined by

$$\begin{aligned} \phi(s) &:= \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j}(s\|x_i - x_j\|)^3}{3k} - k^2 \sum_{i < j} \log(s\|x_i - x_j\|), \\ \phi'(s) &= \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j}\|x_i - x_j\|^3}{k} s^2 - \frac{k^2 n(n-1)}{2s}. \end{aligned}$$

240 The function $\phi(s)$ is convex, and the optimal scaling factor s^* satisfies $\phi'(s^*) = 0$, which
 241 yields

$$s^* = \left(\frac{k^3 n(n-1)}{2 \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3} \right)^{1/3}. \quad (5)$$

242 This value can be computed in $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ complexity, enabling us to obtain a better initial
 243 placement for the problem (1).

244 Notably, the optimal solution to the problem (3) is invariant under scaling. Thus, we
 245 do not have to care about the scale factor for the hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} as far as we scale
 246 the obtained placement by s^* .

Algorithm 1: Proposed algorithm for the initial placement

Input: Graph $G = (V, E)$, Weight $(a_{i,j})_{\{i,j\} \in E}$, Parameters $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}} \in \mathbb{N}$, and $t_0 > 0$
Output: Initial placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$

- 1 $t \leftarrow t_0$;
- 2 Sample $x_i \in Q^{\text{hex}}$ for all $i \in V$ without replacement;
- 3 **for** $m \leftarrow 0$ **to** $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}}$ **do**
- 4 Select vertex $i \in V$ randomly;
- 5 Draw $r \in \mathbb{R}^2$ randomly from a unit circle;
- 6 $x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{round}(x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^{\text{a}}(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^{\text{a}}(x_i) + t \cdot r)$;
- 7 **if** $\exists j \in V$ such that $x_j = x_i^{\text{new}}$ **then**
- 8 $x_j \leftarrow x_i$;
- 9 $x_i \leftarrow x_i^{\text{new}}$;
- 10 $t \leftarrow t - t_0 / N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}}$;
- 11 $x_i \leftarrow s^* x_i$ for all $i \in V$ with s^* given by Eq. (5);
- 12 **return** X

247 4.5 Alternative Approach

248 To end this section, we explain an alternative approach to the problem (3). We can also
 249 solve the problem by updating all vertices simultaneously, not one by one. It means moving
 250 all the points $\{x_i\}_{i \in V}$ to arbitrary positions and then assigning all these $|V|$ points to the
 251 nearest points on Q^{hex} . The optimal assignment for $\{x_i\}_{i \in V}$ to Q^{hex} is computable by a
 252 Hungarian algorithm in $\mathcal{O}(|V|^3)$ time or some heuristic.

253 4.6 Application to Other Force Models

254 We briefly discuss and explore the potential applicability of stochastic coordinate descent
 255 to a broader range of problems. Although we utilized the coordinate Newton direction
 256 only for the optimization problem (1), we can see that its application is not necessarily
 257 limited to the FR force model, the problem (1).

258 Recall that Our optimization problem (1) can be rewritten as

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{FR}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} k^2 \log(\epsilon^r + \|x_i - x_j\|).$$

259 Similar objective functions arise from other force models, such as ... are as follows:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{HC}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} \frac{k_1 (\|x_i - x_j\| - a_{ij})^2}{2} + \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{k_2}{\|x_i - x_j\| + \epsilon^r}$$

260

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{Eades}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} k_1 \|x_i - x_j\| \left(\log \frac{\|x_i - x_j\|}{a_{ij}} - 1 \right) + \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{k_2}{\|x_i - x_j\| + \epsilon^r}$$

261 Clearly, these objective functions are also non-convex and have a similar structure to
 262 $\Phi_{\text{FR}}(X)$, which consists of a sum of terms associated with edges and a sum of terms
 263 associated with all pairs of vertices.

264 The coordinate Newton direction can be computed for each vertex in these models as
 265 well, and the stochastic coordinate descent approach can be applied to optimize the layout
 266 efficiently.

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{KK}}(X) := \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{(\|x_i - x_j\| - l_{ij})^2}{2l_{ij}^2}$$

267

268 5 Numerical Experiment

269 In this section, we evaluate the proposed algorithm with various numerical experiments.
 270 We also confirm that the proposed algorithm efficiently provides a good initial placement
 271 even for larger weighted graphs.

272 5.1 Experimental Setup

273 We conducted all numerical experiments in this section using C++17 compiled by GCC
 274 10.5.0 on a laptop computer powered by Intel(R) Core(TM) i7-10510U CPU with 16 GB
 275 RAM.

276 For a fair comparison, we implemented the FR algorithm in C++ based on NetworkX
 277 version 3.3 [16], SciPy 1.14.1 [32], and utilized the C++ L-BFGS [26, 28] library for the
 278 L-BFGS algorithm. We also referred to the open-source code of the hexagonal grid [27]
 279 and Graphviz version 2.43.0 [10].

280 We used the 3×2 algorithms. As an initial placement, we used

- 281 • random initialization (no prefix),
- 282 • the SA initialization obtained by Simulated Annealing (SA-) [14],
- 283 • the proposed initialization obtained with coordinate Newton direction (CN-).

284 As an algorithm to solve the problem (1), we used

- 285 • FR algorithm (FR),
- 286 • L-BFGS algorithm (L-BFGS).

287 The key remark is that we slightly modified the FR algorithm so that it automatically
 288 adjust the stepsize. This is to isolate the effect of the proposed initialization from the
 289 effect of the stepsize. This is just done by a simple backtracking line search at the first
 290 iteration.

291 As parameters, we used initial temperature $t_0 = 1.5$ and the number of iterations
 292 $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}} = 2|V|^3/|E|$ for Algorithm 1, and we also set the total number of iterations of
 293 Simulated Annealing (SA) in Sec. 3.3 to the same value. Since the Algorithm 1 requires a

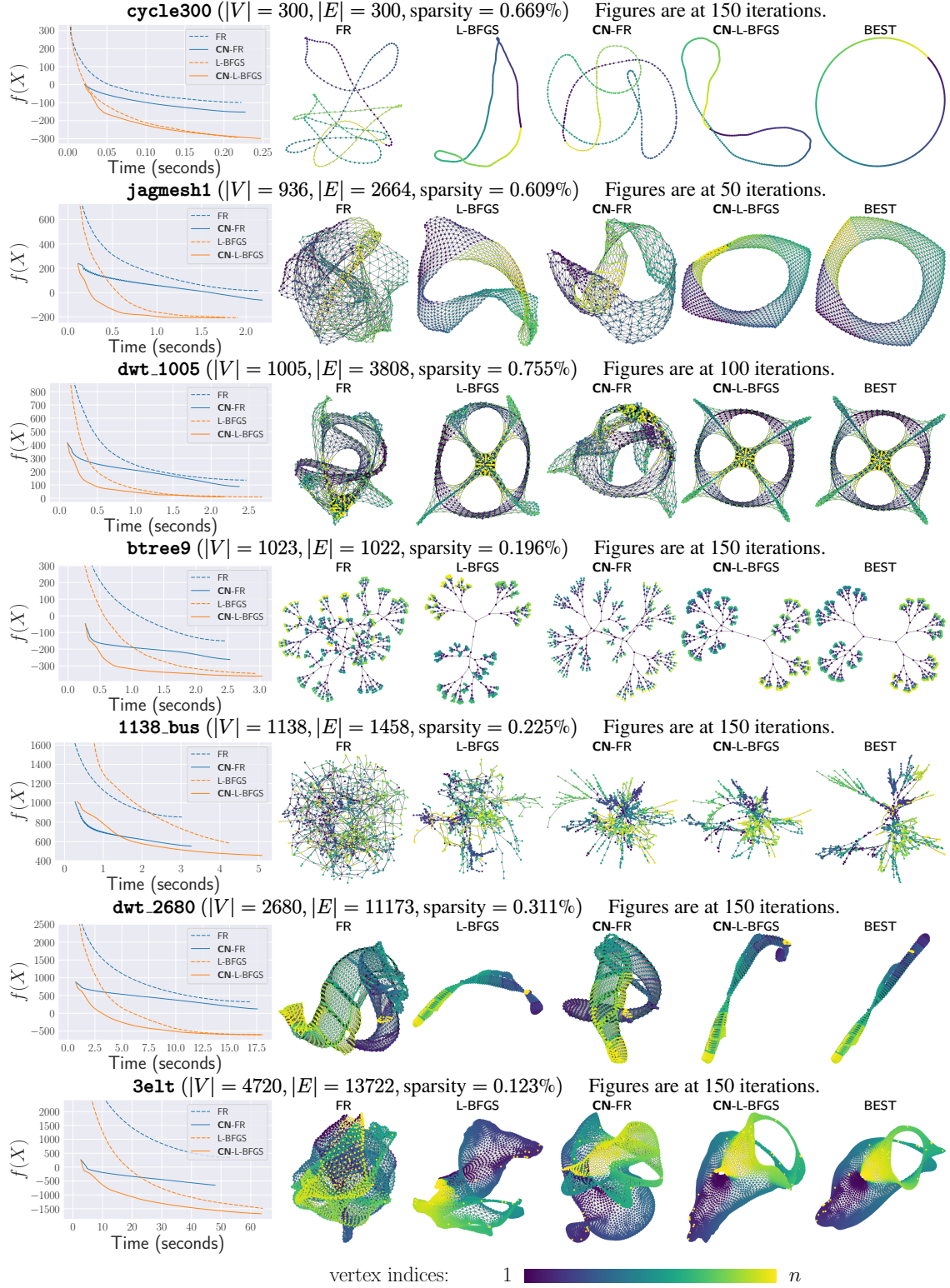


Figure 6: Experimental results. Our proposed method CN, Coordinate Newton, yields improved results for both FR and L-BFGS. The “BEST” reports the performance of CN-L-BFGS within at most 500 iterations. The color of vertices represents their indices.



Figure 7: Comparison of the proposed initialization (CN) with random initialization (no prefix). In almost all cases, the difference is negative, meaning the proposed algorithm performed faster and better than random initialization.

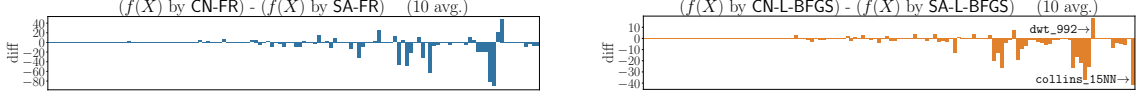


Figure 8: Comparison of the proposed initialization (CN) with SA initialization (SA) in Ref. [14]. In most cases, the proposed algorithm performed better than the SA initialization.

294 computational time proportional to the degree of the selected vertex in each iteration, the
 295 expected computational time per iteration is $\mathcal{O}(|E|/|V|)$. Consequently, we can roughly
 296 estimate that the total computational time of the proposed algorithm is $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$, equivalent
 297 to a few iterations of the FR or L-BFGS algorithms. All the codes are available at
 298 GitHub [19].

299 5.2 Plots and Visualizations

300 We first show the plots and visualizations of the algorithms in Fig. 6. The experiment
 301 details are as follows. We fixed the maximum number of iterations of the FR and L-BFGS
 302 algorithms as $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{LBFGS}} = 200$. We tested with 7 graphs: `cycle300`, `jagmesh1`,
 303 `dwt_1005`, `btree9`, `1138_bus`, `dwt_2680`, and `3elt`. Here `cycle300` is a cycle graph with
 304 300 vertices, and `btree9` is a perfect binary tree with $2^{9+1} - 1 = 1023$ vertices. Other
 305 graphs are from Sparse Matrix Collection [8], and these choices are based on Ref. [35].

306 In Fig. 6, the plots on the left illustrate the objective function values $\Phi(X)$, the average
 307 of the ten trials for each algorithm. The graphs on the right are at the iteration in which
 308 the most significant difference appeared among $\{50, 100, 150\}$ -th iterations (or at the last
 309 iteration if it ended earlier). The vertices in the graphs are colored according to vertex
 310 indices.

311 The observations and implications of Fig. 6 are as follows. First, the plots with solid
 312 lines for CN generally demonstrate superior performance to those with dashed lines for
 313 non-CN. These results validate the efficacy of the proposed method. Secondly, the initial
 314 values of $\Phi(X)$ with CN-FR are significantly smaller than those with FR, suggesting that
 315 the proposed method provides a good initial placement. Thirdly, the visualization results
 316 also support the effectiveness of the proposed initial placement. In most cases, placements
 317 obtained with CN better reflect the nearly optimal arrangement shown in the “BEST”.

318 As a side note, regardless of CN or non-CN, the algorithms with L-BFGS consistently
 319 outperform those with FR. This finding is consistent with prior research [20] and providing
 320 solid evidence for the effectiveness of L-BFGS.

321 **TODO: add more [3]**

322 5.3 Comparison with Other Initializations

323 Next, we conducted experiments to evaluate the performance of the proposed algorithm
 324 (CN) compared to random initialization (no prefix) and SA initialization (SA) with various

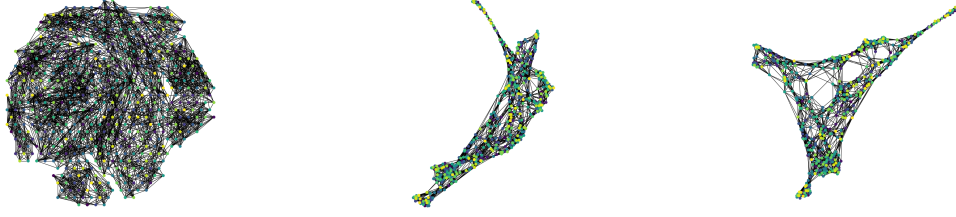


Figure 9: **Spectro_10NN**, where the proposed algorithm performed worse than random initialization. Left: Initial placement by CN. Middle and Right: 50th and 200th iteration of CN-L-BFGS.



Figure 10: An example of a case where $a_{i,j} \notin \{0, 1\}$. Left: the result of CN, which is better as the vertices are separated by colors. Right: the result of SA, which is worse as there is no separation.

325 graphs.

326 We used all undirected, connected, non-negative weighted graphs with 1,000 or fewer
 327 vertices, which can be generated using the matrices from the Sparse Matrix Collection [8]
 328 as adjacency matrices. For fairness, when we compare with SA, we converted the graphs
 329 to an unweighted one. It means that we set weights $a_{i,j}$ to 1 if $a_{i,j} > 0$; otherwise, we set
 330 it to 0.

331 For the algorithms with random initial placement, we set $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{LBFGS}} = 50$,
 332 the same as the default parameter in NetworkX [16]. For the CN algorithms, we set
 333 $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{LBFGS}} = 45$, since the preprocessing step is expected to take as long as a few
 334 iterations of FR or L-BFGS, as mentioned in Sec. 5.1.

335 The results are shown in Figs. 7 and 8. The proposed algorithm performed better than
 336 random or SA initialization, except for a few cases. As for random initialization, one of
 337 such bad cases is **Spectro_10NN** shown in Fig. 9. The proposed algorithm failed to resolve
 338 the twist in the initial placement, shown in the figure, leading to a worse result. Still, the
 339 average performance of ten seeds for **Spectro_10NN** was almost the same as that of the
 340 random initialization. Fig. 11 provides examples for comparison with SA initialization.
 341 The proposed algorithm outperformed in **collins_15NN** and underperformed in **dwt_992**.

342 The interpretation of the results is as follows. First, results in Figs. 7 and 8 strongly
 343 support the effectiveness of the proposed algorithm. It successfully untangles the twists,
 344 leading to better outcomes with faster convergence. Even when the proposed algorithm
 345 performed worse, the difference was insignificant in almost all cases. Secondly, the struc-
 346 tural difference between the initial placement and the optimal placement potentially affects
 347 the convergence speed. For example, the optimal shape of **collins_15NN** is linear, differ-
 348 ing from a circle, resulting in SA's performance being inferior to the proposed algorithm,
 349 whereas the opposite holds for **dwt_992**. Although the proposed method utilizes a hexag-
 350 onal lattice Q^{hex} , alternatives such as Q^{circle} may lead to improved performance of the
 351 proposed method in some cases.

352 Furthermore, although this is a case not considered in Ref. [14], we also conducted
 353 experiments with CN and SA for a case where the edge weight $a_{i,j}$ is not necessarily in

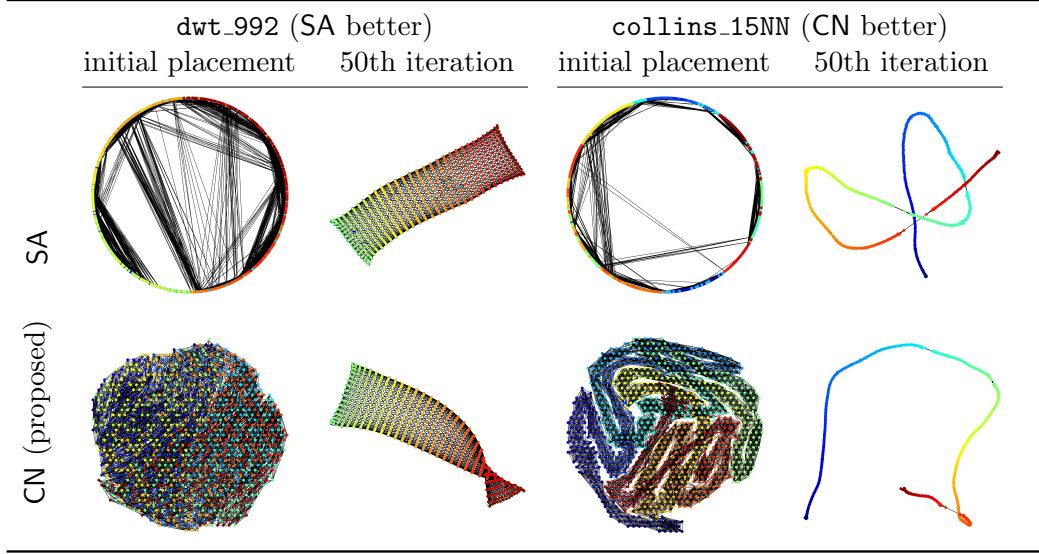


Figure 11: Visualization results showing initial and 50th iteration placements for `dwt_992` and `collins_15NN`.

354 $\{0, 1\}$. We generated a weighted graph with 100 vertices in three groups and 1000 edges
355 randomly, and if the two vertices were in the same group, we set the edge weight to 1.0;
356 otherwise, we set it to 0.1. It exhibits both strong and weak connections. Fig. 10 shows
357 the difference between the two initializations. When we ignore the edge weights and just
358 solve the problem (2), the graph is just an Erdős–Rényi graph, and thus SA cannot find
359 any meaningful structure in the initial placement. In contrast, the proposed algorithm
360 can identify the graph’s structure, and we can observe that the left graph in Fig. 10 is
361 separated into groups, as indicated by the node colors. This result suggests that our
362 proposed algorithm is effective even for weighted graphs, extending the applicability of
363 the preprocessing step.

364 6 Rationale for the Discretization Approach

365 This section explains why we did not apply the coordinate Newton direction technique
366 directly to the original problem (1), but instead first transformed it into the discrete op-
367 timization problem (3). At first sight, one might expect that applying the coordinate
368 Newton method directly to (1) would be more natural and possibly more efficient, since it
369 avoids the detour through discretization. However, as we shall see, this approach suffers
370 from intrinsic difficulties that undermine its effectiveness. By contrast, our discretization-
371 based formulation allows us to circumvent these difficulties while still exploiting the ad-
372 vantages of the coordinate Newton direction. This not only justifies our methodological
373 choice but also provides a foundation for exploring further optimization strategies built
374 upon this framework. In what follows, we clarify the limitations of the direct approach
375 and explain how our method addresses them.

376 6.1 Possible Alternatives

377 One natural idea for solving problem (1) is to apply existing optimization algorithms such
378 as Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD) or Stochastic Coordinate Descent.

379 Applying SGD to graph drawing, particularly to the Kamada–Kawai (KK) layout [22],

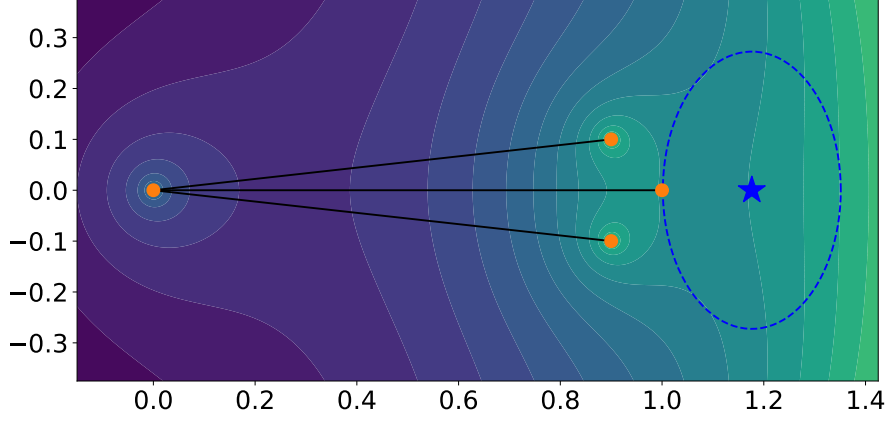


Figure 12: The inaccurate quadratic approximation. The blue star indicates the optimal solution for the quadratic approximation of $\Phi_1(x_1)$, but this differs significantly from the situation shown by the contour lines.

has been a notable direction [1, 35]. The KK model determines the layout by minimizing a stress-like energy $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$ defined for all vertex pairs. SGD corresponds to randomly selecting an edge i, j and updating x_i and x_j using the gradient of $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$. This stochastic treatment reduces per-iteration complexity while retaining structural information, as $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$ is defined in terms of graph distance.

In contrast, applying SGD directly to the FR model is ineffective. When $a_{i,j} = 0$, the energy term reduces to $\Phi_{i,j} = -k^2 \log d$, which depends only on Euclidean distance and ignores the graph structure. Consequently, gradients from a single sampled pair often fail to provide meaningful information for optimization.

Another approach is to use Stochastic Coordinate Descent, which resembles Randomized Subspace Newton methods [4, 12, 15, 18, 25]. For each vertex i , define the local energy

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|), \quad (6)$$

whose gradient (the net force on i) and Hessian are

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j), \\ \nabla^2 \Phi_i(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + \\ &\quad \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j}}{k \|x_i - x_j\|} + \frac{2k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^4} \right) (x_i - x_j)(x_i - x_j)^\top. \end{aligned}$$

A direct SCD scheme randomly selects a vertex i , applies Newton's method (or a regularized variant) to Φ_i using the above gradient and Hessian, and updates x_i iteratively until convergence.

Although reasonable in spirit, this approach is also ineffective in practice. In the following, we illustrate the reasons for this failure with nontrivial examples.

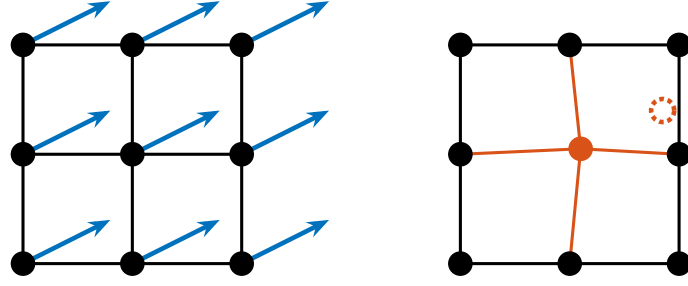


Figure 13: The blue arrows represent the acting forces in this situation. The center vertex exhibits only a minor shift in the coordinate Newton direction, while the red dashed vertex marks its ideal configuration.

6.2 Inaccuracy of Quadratic Approximation

One of the reasons it fails is the inaccuracy of the quadratic approximation; specifically, a particular issue arises when we restrict the optimization to a coordinate block.

Let G be a graph with $V = \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ and $E = \{\{1, 2\}, \{2, 3\}, \{2, 4\}\}$. Set $k = 1/2$ and assign all positive edge weights $a_{i,j} = 1$ for every edge in E . The position of the vertices is

$$X = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0.9 & 0.9 \\ 0 & 0 & +0.1 & -0.1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

We show the contour of $\Phi_1(x_1)$ in Fig. 12. The key point of this example is that the Hessian

$$\nabla^2 \Phi_1(x_1) = \begin{pmatrix} 4.25 & 0 \\ 0 & 1.75 \end{pmatrix}$$

is positive definite and well-conditioned. Despite this favorable property of the Hessian, the coordinate Newton direction for x_1 results in a deviation from the global optimum. This issue arises from the inaccurate approximation of Φ_1 in the restricted block coordinates x_1 . The attractive force from vertex 2 and the repulsive forces from vertices 3 and 4 cancel each other out, leading to a highly inaccurate quadratic approximation. This deficiency cannot be entirely resolved by modifying Newton's method, as it is an intrinsic and unavoidable limitation of the stochastic coordinate descent.

6.3 Ignorance of Other Vertices' Movements

Another reason is the ignorance of other vertices' movements when optimizing each vertex individually. When optimizing for a vertex i , the coordinate Newton direction treats all other vertices $V \setminus \{i\}$ as fixed.

Fig. 13 illustrates this issue. Consider a subset of vertices forming a mesh-like structure in G , where all vertices receive forces in the directions indicated by the blue arrows. In this situation, the FR and L-BFGS algorithms move all vertices simultaneously, allowing the simulation or optimization to proceed without issues. In contrast, the stochastic coordinate descent, as shown on the right side of the figure, brings stagnation. Here, all other vertices are considered fixed. Thus, optimizing the red vertex results in minimal movement, as its directly connected neighbors impede it. As a result, even after numerous iterations, little optimization is achieved. Thus, ignoring the movements of other vertices can be a significant limitation of the coordinate Newton method.

6.4 Rationale for Proposed Method

Our proposed method resolves issues in Secs. 6.2 and 6.3 by transforming the problem (1) into the problem (3) in Sec. 4.2, and optimizing Φ_i^a on Q^{hex} .

Regarding the issue in Sec. 6.2, this transformation brings the convexity of the objective function as it treats the repulsive forces via a hexagonal lattice, making the quadratic approximation more accurate than the original problem. Regarding the issue in Sec. 6.3, the discrete point set Q ensures that the stepsize is larger than ϵ , as each point is always separated by at least ϵ . This large stepsize prevents stagnation in the optimization, and helps explore the solution space more efficiently. Furthermore, this transformation also brings the benefit of reducing computational complexity from $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ to $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$.

Thus, converting the problem is crucial to provide a high-quality initial placement with the coordinate Newton direction. There may also be better transformation methods, and further exploration is warranted.

7 Conclusion

In this study, we proposed a new initial placement with the coordinate Newton direction for the FR force model, the problem (1). The obtained initial placements have fewer twists than the random initialization, leading to faster convergence and better visualization. Numerical experiments revealed that the proposed method is effective across various graphs, extending the applicability of the preprocessing step. The proposed method may advance the graph drawing, and we also hope it highlights the potential of the stochastic coordinate descent and its variants for addressing a broader range of graph-related optimization problems.

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A NetworkX Implementation

As supplementary information, this section explains how to solve the problem (1) and obtain the final placement. At the time of writing, NetworkX, an open-source library for graph analysis in Python, is set to release the L-BFGS-based method that we have implemented. Although this method does not use our proposed initial placement, we provide some implementation details as a reference in Sec. A.3.

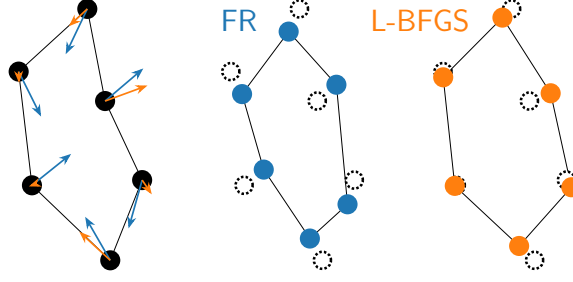


Figure 14: Comparison of the FR and L-BFGS algorithms. Blue arrows represent fixed stepsizes in FR, whereas orange arrows represent adaptive stepsizes determined by the approximate inverse Hessian

581 A.1 Fruchterman–Reingold Algorithm

Algorithm 2: Fruchterman–Reingold algorithm

Input: Graph $G = (V, E)$, Weights $(a_{i,j})_{\{i,j\} \in E}$, Parameters $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} \in \mathbb{N}$, $t_0 > 0$,
and Initial placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$

Output: Final placement X

```

1  $t \leftarrow t_0$ ;
2 for  $m \leftarrow 1$  to  $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}}$  do
3   compute gradient  $\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)$  for all  $i \in V$ ;
4    $x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow x_i - t \frac{\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)}{\|\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)\|}$  for all  $i \in V$ ;
5    $x_i \leftarrow x_i^{\text{new}}$ ;
6    $t \leftarrow t - t_0 / N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}}$ ;
7   if convergence condition is satisfied then
8     break;
9 return  $X$ ;
```

583 The Fruchterman–Reingold algorithm [11] is the original and most standard approach
584 to obtain the equilibrium state of the force model. The pseudo-code is shown in Algo-
585 rithm 2, which is a variant of the gradient (steepest) descent method with the function Φ_i
586 in Eq. (6) [30].

587 Algorithm 2 is based on the original pseudo-code [11] and implementation in Net-
588 workX [16] with some omitted details. We typically draw the initial placement X from a
589 uniform distribution on $[0, 1]^{2 \times n}$. The parameter t denotes the temperature, which gov-
590 erns the stepsize along the steepest descent. As the temperature gradually decreases, the
591 algorithm converges to a particular placement, which is not necessarily a local optimum
592 of the problem (1).

593 A.2 L-BFGS Algorithm

594 Another approach is to leverage the L-BFGS algorithm [20]. Using only a few recent
595 gradient vectors, the L-BFGS algorithm approximates the inverse Hessian of the objective
596 function Φ [24]. L-BFGS is known to be very efficient for large-scale optimization problems.
597 We can apply the L-BFGS algorithm to the optimization problem (1) via flattening the
598 matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ to a vector $\bar{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{2n}$. Refer to Fig. 14 for a comparison to the FR
599 algorithm.

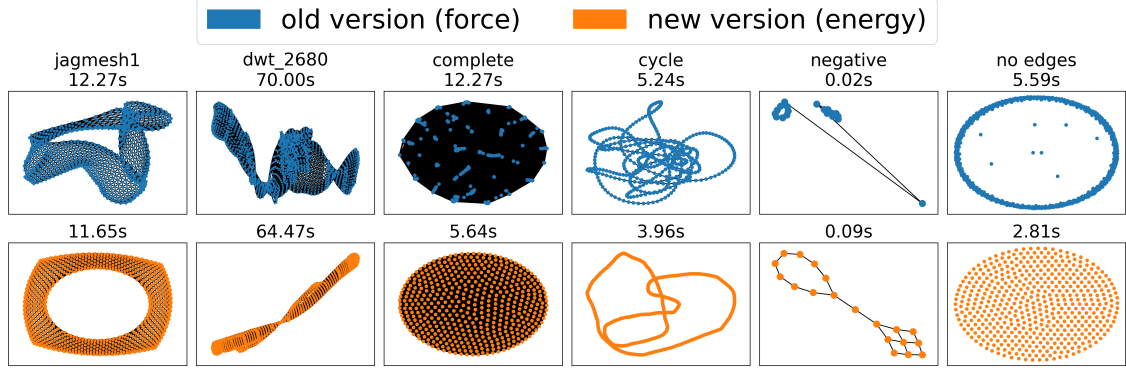


Figure 15: The FR algorithm and L-BFGS algorithm in NetworkX.

A.3 NetworkX Implementation

In this subsection, we explain the details of our NetworkX implementation. Refer to Fig. 15 for a comparison to the FR algorithm. The problem setting considered in NetworkX is similar to that described in Sec. 2, but there are some key differences. First, the number of dimensions is not always two. Since the extension of the method is straightforward, we restrict our discussion to two-dimensional layouts. Other than that, the following differences exist:

- Negative edge weights are allowed.
- Directed graphs are supported, not just undirected graphs.
- The graph is not always connected.

Under these settings, the problem (1) can be unbounded. It means that the optimal solution does not exist in a finite region. When edge weights are negative or the graph is disconnected, i.e., when it consists of $m > 1$ connected components ($V = \bigoplus_{j=1}^m V_j$), the solution may be unbounded, since the farther apart the vertices are, the lower the energy.

To overcome this issue, we do the following suitable modifications. First, when the graph has negative edge weights, one may transform them into non-negative values, for example, by taking their absolute values. Second, when the graph is a directed one, only the sum $a_{i,j} + a_{j,i}$ matters in the formulation, so symmetrization is sufficient. Thus, the directed and possibly negatively weighted adjacency matrix $\tilde{A} = (\tilde{a}_{i,j}) \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ can be transformed into a symmetric matrix $A = (a_{i,j})$, where $a_{i,j} = (|\tilde{a}_{i,j}| + |\tilde{a}_{j,i}|)/2 \geq 0$. Third, we add additional forces to the energy function to prevent the divergence of each connected component. In general, adding terms that attract each group to the center is a common approach to avoid unboundedness. We adopt this approach with the center $x_{\text{center}} = (0.5, 0.5)^\top$, as it is the center of the expected layout bounding box.

Based on Sec. 2, let us define the sum of terms associated with the vertex x_i be Φ_i , which is explicitly given by

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} (\Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|) + \Phi_{j,i}(\|x_j - x_i\|)).$$

The i -th row of the gradient $\nabla \Phi(X) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ is

$$(\nabla \Phi(X))_i^\top = \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) = \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{(a_{i,j} + a_{j,i})\|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{2k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j)$$

$$= 2 \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j).$$

627 To obtain the final layout while preventing the divergence, we need to minimize $\Phi(X) +$
 628 $f_g(X)$, where $f_g(X)$ is the additional term. Let the center of gravity of the j -th connected
 629 component V_j ($1 \leq j \leq m$) be $g_j := \frac{1}{|V_j|} \sum_{i \in V_j} x_i$. Then, using some constant $c_g > 0$, we
 630 define the additional force as

$$\Phi_g(X) := c_g \sum_{j=1}^m \frac{|V_j|}{2} \|g_j - x_{\text{center}}\|_2^2,$$

631 with the gradient

$$(\nabla \Phi_g(X))_i = c_g (g_j - x_{\text{center}}) \quad \text{where } i \in V_j.$$

632 We can now apply the L-BFGS algorithm to these functions to derive the algorithm.
 633 Further implementation details and experimental results are available in [our merged pull](#)
 634 [request](#) to the NetworkX.